Resource Management
Critical Thinking
Applied Academic Skills
Information Use

Money Management

Part 2: Save Money Before You Spend It

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Courseware Version: 1.0 and subsequent updates

LESSON BASICS

Lesson Topic

Money Management, Part 2 of 9: Save Money Before You Spend It. One concept taught in about 10 minutes through The Cushion Challenge.

Standards (CCRS, GED Standard, Employability Skills Framework)

- WS.RM: Manages Money
- AK.CTS: Makes Sound Decisions
- AK.CTS: Plans and Organizes
- AK.AAS: Uses Mathematical Strategies and Procedures

Objectives (Audience Behavior Condition Degree)

Given a fictional family's four paydays in The Cushion Challenge, learners will make a save-first plan that sets how much to save first, where the savings is kept, how it is made automatic, and who to ask before saving affects benefits, giving a reason for each choice.

Learners will choose one private first step to take this week.

Assessment

Teacher observation of class decisions during the game and the How It Went discussion. Learners complete a My First Step choice. Part 2 items will be added to the module pre/post test, exit ticket, and rubric.

LESSON MATERIALS

Handouts Needed

- My First Step card (one per learner)
- Money Management module rubric (module-wide)

Online Resources

- The Cushion Challenge: lesson-Money-Management/cushion-challenge.html
- Part 2 Teacher's Guide: Teacher-Resources/Part2_Save_First_Teachers_Guide.pdf
- Meet Jess video with captions: lesson-Money-Management/Meet_Jess.mp4 (plays inside the game)

Other Materials or Equipment

- Computer, projector, or smart board
- Learner devices (optional)
- Pens or pencils

ACTIVITY PLAN

Time	Activity	Materials
Warm-up **1 minute**	Open The Cushion Challenge on the classroom screen, press Start over, and check that Class mode is On. Play the one-minute Meet Jess video to introduce Jess, a fictional mom of two who found work through SPOKES and still gets SNAP. Ask: "What is one surprise cost families run into?" Take the kind of cost, never an amount. Remind learners that Jess's numbers are made up and no one shares their own money.	Cushion Challenge: Meet Jess screen Video: Meet Jess (captioned) Projector or smart board, speakers
Introduction **Under 1 minute**	State the one idea of Part 2: save a little first, automatically, somewhere safe, so a small cushion protects your family. You can do it while on benefits. Point to the cushion meter and the $250 goal line. Explain that the class will vote on Jess's choices for four paydays by calling out a letter, A to D. For each vote: click the class's pick (or press its letter), ask one or two learners why, then click Reveal what happens.	Cushion meter and goal line
Presentation **4 minutes**	Payday 1: the class decides whether Jess saves first or saves what is left. Read the pay-yourself-first pop-up. Payday 2: the class chooses where her savings lives, whether to split her direct deposit automatically, and whether school pictures are an emergency or a planned cost. Read each pop-up as it appears.	Cushion Challenge: Paydays 1-2 Teacher's Guide, Chapter 3
Practice **3 minutes**	Payday 3: a flat tire tests Jess's cushion. The class then decides what Jess should do when a friend says saving will cost her SNAP (ask her caseworker). Payday 4: the class decides how much of Jess's tax refund goes to savings before it is spent.	Cushion Challenge: Paydays 3-4 Teacher's Guide, Chapter 4
Evaluation **1 minute**	Review the How It Went screen: Jess's final cushion, what helped, and what held her back. Ask which one choice made the biggest difference. Use the class's votes during the game as evidence for the objective.	Cushion Challenge: How It Went screen Module rubric
Application **1 minute**	The last screen lists five first steps. Each learner circles one on a paper My First Step card. The amount line is optional, and cards are not collected.	Cushion Challenge: Your Turn screen My First Step card (paper)

Other Resources or Alternative Resources

- Jess and every number in the game are fictional. Learners never share their own income, benefits, or balances.

- If a learner asks about their own benefits, point them to their caseworker. Give no eligibility advice, and do not quote a WV WORKS dollar limit until the team verifies it.

- Class mode is on by default: large text for a projector, lettered choices, and answers that wait for the teacher to reveal them. One-on-one: turn Class mode off. Virtual: keep it on, share your screen, and take letter votes in the chat.

- Sources behind the pop-ups: Urban Institute, Thriving Residents, Thriving Cities (April 2016); CFPB, Your Money, Your Goals savings booklet; Bank On National Account Standards 2025-2026; USDA FNS SNAP broad-based categorical eligibility chart (June 2026); IRS, splitting federal refunds.